

Getting Ready for Remote Learning with FOSS



The COVID-19 pandemic has made it mandatory to adapt to information and communication technology tools to enable remote learning. This article explores various free and open source tools that enable academia to cater to the needs of students. Tools for various functions such as learning management systems (LMS), video conferencing, building educational resources and evaluation are explored in this article.

The application of information and communication technology (ICT) has been a topic of discussion in academic circles for the past few decades. However, with the sudden disruption caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, ICT has emerged from being a nice-to-have component into becoming one that's mandatory. Earlier, the perception was that ICT could enhance the teaching-learning process. Now it is becoming a platform to enable the teaching-learning process.

With the COVID-19-linked lockdown, academia is now forced to change its standard operating procedures. It has become necessary for teachers, students and parents to adapt themselves to this sudden change with the help of ICT tools, as these facilitate uninterrupted continuation of the teaching-learning process. This article explores various free and open source tools that enable academia to deliver services in the best possible manner.

Why FOSS?

Though there are many proprietary and paid software to enable the teaching-learning process, they involve recurrent licensing costs that might not be affordable for all in a diverse country like ours. One of the most important factors in selecting an ICT tool is inclusion. We need to make sure every possible learner is included. Free and open source software (FOSS) is certainly better in terms of inclusion because it removes the cost of the software from the scheme of things. Another important advantage is that FOSS can be customised to specific needs and redistributed to the needy without the need for any permissions.

Is it only for video conferencing?

It's no wonder that video conferencing tools have suddenly become household names with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. Teachers across the globe have also started using video conferencing tools to communicate with their students. However, video conferencing alone doesn't constitute the complete teaching-learning process. It includes so many other activities as well. Each of these activities might require specific tools and hence it is important to know the right tools for each task. The major tasks involved are listed below:

- Building learning resources
- Communicating with the learners
- Conducting the evaluation process

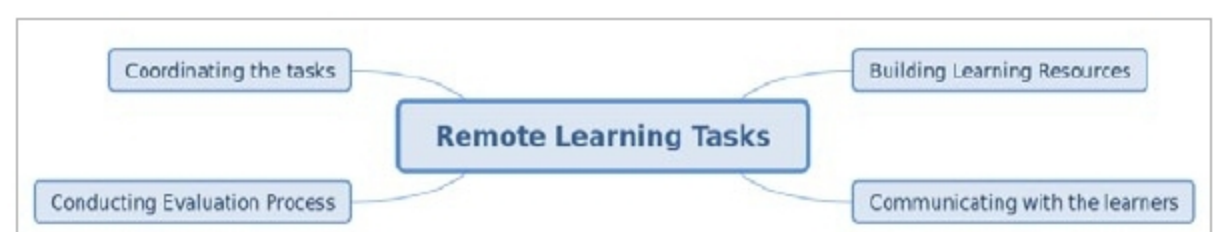


Figure 1: Major tasks in remote learning

